

U1L03 Quick Reference — HTML Text Formatting

Tag Table

Tag	Purpose	Closing?	Example
<code><h1></code> – <code><h6></code>	Headings, 1 = biggest	Yes	<code><h1>My Site</h1></code>
<code><p></code>	Paragraph	Yes	<code><p>Some text.</p></code>
<code></code>	Important	Yes	<code>Warning</code>
<code></code>	Stressed when read aloud	Yes	<code>really</code>
<code></code>	Thicker, no added meaning	Yes	<code>keyword</code>
<code><i></code>	Slanted, no added meaning	Yes	<code><i>The Martian</i></code>
<code>
</code>	Line break	No	Line 1 Line 2
<code><hr></code>	Topic divider	No	<code><hr></code>
<code><!-- --></code>	Comment	n/a	<code><!-- note --></code>

The Whitespace Rule

HTML collapses all spaces, tabs, and blank lines into one space.

```
<body>
  Welcome to my site
  My name is Alex
</body>
```

Shows as: Welcome to my site My name is Alex

💡 Pressing Enter does nothing. Structure comes from **tags**, never from your spacing.

Headings

```
<h1>Main Title</h1>
<h2>Major Section</h2>
<h3>Subsection</h3>
<h4>Sub-subsection</h4>
<h5>Minor Heading</h5>
<h6>Smallest Heading</h6>
```

Bigger number = smaller text.

Rule	Why
One <code><h1></code> per page	It titles the whole page
Never skip a level	<code>h1</code> → <code>h3</code> sounds like a missing chapter
Descriptive names	"Contact Information", not "Section 2"

⚠️ Never pick a heading for its size. Size is CSS's job — Unit 2.

Correct outline

```
<h1>My Personal Website</h1>

<h2>About Me</h2>
  <h3>Where I Grew Up</h3>

<h2>My Hobbies</h2>
  <h3>Basketball</h3>
  <h3>Music</h3>
```

💡 Indenting is for you. The browser reads the **numbers**.

Bold & Italic

`<b>` and `<strong>` look **identical** on screen. So do `<i>` and `<em>`.

Tag	Says	Screen reader
<code></code>	"This is important"	Stresses it
<code></code>	"Stress this out loud"	Stresses it
<code></code>	"Make it thicker"	Reads it flat
<code><i></code>	"Make it slanted"	Reads it flat

```
<p>This is <strong>important</strong> and I <em>mean</em> it.</p>
```

Default to `<strong>` and `<em>`.

When `<i>` is actually right:

```
<p>The book <i>The Martian</i> got me into science.</p>
```

A book title is italic by convention — but it isn't *more important* than the words around it, so `<em>` would be wrong.

Line Breaks & Dividers

`<br>` — new line, same idea

```
<p>P. Sherman<br>42 Wallaby Way<br>Sydney, Australia</p>
```

Without `<br>`, the whitespace rule squashes it into one line.

<hr> — topic change

```
<p>Content above.</p>
<hr>
<p>Content below.</p>
```

Self-closing

✓	✗
 	 </br>
<hr>	<hr></hr>

💡 There's no text *inside* a line break. Nothing to wrap means nothing to close.

<p> or
 ?

Use	For
<p>	A new idea
 	A new line inside the same idea

⚠️ Never stack

 to fake spacing.

Nesting

First opened, last closed.

```
<p>This is <strong><em>extremely</em></strong> important.</p>
```

Correct	Wrong
text	text

💡 Like boxes: you can't shut the big lid while the small box is sticking out. Same as parentheses in math — ([]), never ([)] .

Comments

```
<!-- Navigation section starts here -->
<h2>Menu</h2>
```

Invisible on the page. Visible in your code.

Shortcut: `Ctrl + /` (Win) · `Cmd + /` (Mac)

Use them to **label sections**, **explain a decision**, or **turn off code** without deleting it.

Complete Working Page

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="UTF-8">
  <title>Movie Review</title>
</head>
<body>
  <!-- Page title -->
  <h1>My Favorite Movie</h1>

  <p><strong>Inception</strong> is the <em>best</em> movie I have seen.</p>

  <hr>

  <!-- Movie facts -->
  <h2>Details</h2>
  <p>Director: Christopher Nolan<br>
  Year: 2010</p>
</body>
</html>
```

Fixes

Problem	Cause	Fix
Everything on one line	Whitespace collapsed	Wrap in <code><p></code>
Bold never stops	Missing closing tag	Add <code></code>
Formatting bleeds into next section	Crossed nesting	Close inner tag first
Comment shows on page	Typo in <code><!--</code> or <code>--></code>	Check both ends
Address squished	Missing breaks	Add <code>
</code> per line
Heading looks wrong size	Wrong tag for the job	Pick by meaning, style in CSS
Nothing changed	Didn't save	<code>Ctrl/Cmd + S</code>

Vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Whitespace	Spaces, tabs, and line breaks in your code
Semantic	Markup describing what content <i>means</i>
Screen reader	Software that reads a page aloud for blind users
Self-closing	A tag with no content and no closing tag
Nesting	Tags inside other tags